A HISTORY OF BANGLADESH

SECOND EDITION

WILLEM VAN SCHENDEL
University of Amsterdam

Ayesha Abed Library
Acc. no. 41970
Class no. 954.92
Aut. mark SCH Pub. Yr. 2020
Copy 1 Date 3.12.2023

CAMBRIDGE
UNIVERSITY PRESS

CAMBRIDGE
UNIVERSITY PRESS

University Printing House, Cambridge CB2 8BS, United Kingdom

One Liberty Plaza, 20th Floor, New York, NY 10006, USA

477 Williamstown Road, Port Melbourne, VIC 3207, Australia

314–321, 3rd Floor, Plot 3, Splendor Forum, Jasola District Centre,
New Delhi – 110025, India

79 Anson Road, #06–04/06, Singapore 079906

Cambridge University Press is part of the University of Cambridge.

It furthers the University's mission by disseminating knowledge in the pursuit of education, learning and research at the highest international levels of excellence.

www.cambridge.org
Information on this title: www.cambridge.org/9781108473699
DOI: 10.1017/9781108684644

First edition © Cambridge University Press 2009
Second edition © Willem van Schendel 2020

This publication is in copyright. Subject to statutory exception and to the provisions of relevant collective licensing agreements, no reproduction of any part may take place without the written permission of Cambridge University Press.

First published 2009
3rd printing 2015
Second edition 2020

Printed in the United Kingdom by TJ International Ltd, Padstow, Cornwall

A catalogue record for this publication is available from the British Library.

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data
NAMES: Schendel, Willem van, author.
TITLE: A history of Bangladesh / Willem van Schendel, University of Amsterdam.
DESCRIPTION: Second edition. | Cambridge, United Kingdom ; New York : Cambridge University Press, 2020. | Includes bibliographical references and index.
IDENTIFIERS: LCCN 2020009196 | ISBN 9781108473699 (hardback) | ISBN 9781108684644 (ebook)
SUBJECTS: LCSH: Bangladesh – History.
CLASSIFICATION: LCC DS394.5 .S34 2020 | DDC 954.92–dc23
LC record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2020009196

ISBN 978-1-108-47369-9 Hardback
ISBN 978-1-108-46246-4 Paperback

Cambridge University Press has no responsibility for the persistence or accuracy of URLs for external or third-party internet websites referred to in this publication and does not guarantee that any content on such websites is, or will remain, accurate or appropriate.

Contents

List of Plates *page* vii
List of Maps and Figures xv
Preface to Second Edition xvii
Acknowledgements xix
Timeline xxi
Introduction xxix

PART I THE LONG VIEW 1

1 A Land of Water and Silt 3
2 Jungle, Fields, Cities and States 11
3 A Region of Multiple Frontiers 24
4 The Delta as a Crossroads 43

PART II COLONIAL ENCOUNTERS 53

5 From the Mughal Empire to the British Empire 55
6 British Legacies 63
7 A Closing Agrarian Frontier 82
8 Colonial Conflicts 93
9 Towards Partition 104
10 Partition 112
11 Population Exchange 121

CamScanner

PART III BECOMING EAST PAKISTAN 127

12 The Pakistan Experiment 129

13 Pakistan Falls Apart 144

14 East Pakistani Livelihoods 154

15 The Roots of Aid Dependence 166

16 A New Elite and Cultural Renewal 174

PART IV WAR AND THE BIRTH OF BANGLADESH 181

17 Armed Conflict 183

18 A State Is Born 197

19 Imagining a New Nation 208

PART V INDEPENDENT BANGLADESH 217

20 Shaping a Political System 219

21 The Triumph of Identity Politics 231

22 Transnational Linkages 256

23 Boom or Bust? 275

24 Gender Movements 300

25 A National Culture? 312

Conclusion 333

Bangladesh District Maps 335
Key Political Figures since 1947 337
Glossary of Bengali Terms 347
Notes 352
Bibliography 370
Index 415

CamScanner

CHAPTER 6

British Legacies

European rule brought the people of Bengal economic upheaval, a social shake-up and a cultural kick in the teeth. The British were unlike the Mughals – they wanted more than just to extract Bengal's riches. It was their ambition to transform Bengal's economy to make it yield them much more income. To this end they combined experiences from Britain and Ireland with South Asian practices, subjecting the population of Bengal to an endless series of social, administrative and economic experiments.

Some of these turned out to be successful, others were downright disastrous. The early introduction of a system of increased tax collection proved to be calamitous in the uncertain natural conditions of Bengal. It was applied rigidly despite a depletion of people's incomes as a result of drought and then floods in 1769–70. Together with unchecked profiteering in the food-grain markets, this led to intense suffering and an epic famine which is still remembered as the 'Great Famine of 1176' (*chhiyāttarer manbantar*).* It is thought that one third of Bengal's population, or a staggering 10 million people, perished. This is how a nineteenth-century researcher described the famine:

> All through the stifling summer of 1770 the people went on dying. The husbandmen sold their cattle; they sold their implements of agriculture; they devoured their seed-grain; they sold their sons and daughters, till at length no buyer of children could be found; they ate the leaves of trees and the grass of the field; and in June, 1770, the Resident at the Durbar affirmed that the living were feeding on the dead. Day and night a torrent of famished and disease-stricken wretches poured into the great cities. At an early period of the year pestilence had broken out. In March we find small-pox at Moorshedabad [Murshidabad] . . . The streets were blocked up with promiscuous heaps of the dying and dead. Interment could not do its work quick enough; even the dogs and jackals, the public scavengers of the

* The Bengali calendar differs from the Common Era calendar (CE) in its starting point. It has solar years and each year begins in mid-April. Thus the year 2000 CE equals the year 1406/7 BE (Bengali Era) and the Great Famine of 1176 refers to the year 1769/70. For details, see Van Schendel (2001a).

East, became unable to accomplish their revolting work, and the multitude of mangled and festering corpses at length threatened the existence of the citizens . . . In 1770, the rainy season brought relief, and before the end of September the province reaped an abundant harvest. But the relief came too late to avert depopulation. Starving and shelterless crowds crawled despairingly from one deserted village to another in a vain search for food, or a resting-place in which to hide themselves from the rain. The epidemics incident to the season were thus spread over the whole country; and, until the close of the year, disease continued so prevalent as to form a subject of communication from the government in Bengal to the Court of Directors [in London]. Millions of famished wretches died in the struggle to live through the few intervening weeks that separated them from the harvest, their last gaze being probably fixed on the densely-covered fields that would ripen only a little too late for them.[1]

This unconscionable debacle forced the British overlords to find more sustainable ways of exploiting the resources of their new colony. They developed a plethora of policies that shaped a new colonial society. Historians of Bengal, who have concentrated their studies mostly on the British colonial period, have provided us with a richly textured and enormously detailed understanding of the complex social, economic and cultural permutations of Bengal under British rule between 1757 and 1947.[2] Here we highlight only a few major effects of special significance for the emergence of post-colonial Bangladesh.

A STATE SHAPED BY UNRULY NATURE

It was not easy to embed colonial governance in the water-soaked active delta. Ecological conditions and the extreme monsoon climate made this a landscape in continual flux. Like all rulers before and after them, the British had to deal with constantly moving land–water frontiers, impermanent rural settlements and the seasonality of communications. The unpredictability of nature, combined with heightened state ambitions, required flexible forms of administration.

But how to go about it? Early-colonial officials 'operated with two competing narratives – one coloured by their experiences of the devastating natural disasters and the other by their own ambition to establish an ordered agrarian landscape'.[3] This dilemma played out in many ways, for example, in the location of district towns, the nodes of state governance in the countryside. The British had serious apprehensions about health, natural hazards and the presumed delicacy of the European body – and these were as important as, and sometimes trumped, issues of central location with regard to tax collection and political and military

control. District towns 'were invariably located on easily drainable and elevated land'. Even so, new worries about Europeans' health could lead to such towns being dismantled, as in the case of the district town of Backergunj in southern Bengal – it was relocated to Borishal (Barisal) town in 1801.[4]

Early-colonial officials were pulled between trying to constrain a rapid territorial advance – which could turn out to be reckless and expensive – and pushing ahead in search of more profit and revenue. As a result, the territorial expansion under the British East India Company – a mercantile corporation more interested in profits than in territorial control – proceeded haphazardly and in a much less resolute manner than many later observers assumed. This was not the story of an all-powerful juggernaut – a colonial state bullying a helpless colonised society into submission. It was the story of a budding state apparatus being at the mercy of natural and social forces and gingerly feeling its way forward.

The British had great difficulty devising bureaucratic, technical and legal tools to cope with the delta ecology. Their attempts to survey the territory and establish stable relationships with their colonial subjects were often defeated by nature's volatility. It was essential to survey the labyrinthine network of delta rivers and embankments, but this was an uphill task.[5] From year to year rivers wandered and submerged cultivated fields, threatening tax income and prompting cultivators to move to a new house and reclaim forests. Carefully drawn maps of the territory became obsolete within years. General rules turned out not to be applicable because local conditions varied enormously and were changing all the time. And local understandings of rights in land, produce, water and forests were difficult to codify in a flexible way. State officials were constantly struggling to make sense of the capricious natural environment – their actions were always shaped by climate and landscape. Numerous endlessly 'touring' officials embodied the day-to-day fluidity of governance. All over provincial Bengal, resthouses and temporary residences were constructed for these travellers, and the circuit houses, postal bungalows (*ḍāk bāṃlā*) and forest lodges that they frequented are still in official use today.

The early-colonial bureaucratic and legal solutions that the British devised to cope would cast a shadow of centuries: their after-effects are still noticeable in Bangladesh today, a new state faced with the same natural volatility. Among the most momentous solutions was a novel system of land rights and taxation that came to be known as the 'permanent settlement'.

CamScanner

THE PERMANENT SETTLEMENT

The permanent settlement was a system of land rights and taxation that enabled the British to distance their administration from the vagaries of nature and climate in the Bengal delta.[6] Introduced in 1790 and codified in 1793, it was important because it was more than merely a tax system. It formed the nucleus of the colonial system of control; other parts of the administration such as the executive, the judiciary and the police were geared to the desired working of the permanent settlement.[7] It survived with modifications into the 1950s and moulded social and economic relations in the delta to such an extent that contemporary Bangladesh society cannot be understood without reference to it.

The permanent settlement was a deal that the British East India Company struck with the tax-collecting rural gentry, the zamindars. The British (who arrogated the ultimate property rights of all land in Bengal) changed the role of the zamindars, who had previously been hereditary revenue farmers. They now became *de facto* landowners and the peasants became their tenants. The British fixed the tax demand in perpetuity and pledged that they would not enhance the rate in future. In return, the zamindars were bound to pay their taxes to the state, collected from their tenants, with clockwork punctuality on pain of their land being auctioned off. Such auctions happened quite regularly, ruining old landed families and making zamindari status attainable for moneyed social climbers.

The permanent settlement harnessed zamindari dominance of local society to the colonial regime, and zamindars became the mainstay of colonial control and extraction.[8] At the same time their power was circumscribed by the threat of expropriation in case of arrears in tax payments to the state. The British rulers had created an effective human buffer – the zamindars – between themselves and the capriciousness of the Bengal delta's environment and climate.

The administrative category of zamindar concealed an immense social spectrum. In some regions zamindars were opulent titled princes with enormous estates. Take the Rajshahi Raj family: it held sway over an estate of 13,000 km^2 and lived in a palace in Nator that is today owned by the Bangladesh state and in use as its Northern People's Mansion (*uttarā gaṇabhaban*). In other regions (for example Chittagong) zamindari holdings were typically much smaller, and sometimes tiny. Moreover, inheritance rules were partible, so over time zamindari rights came to be shared by many descendants; it was not at all uncommon to come across individuals who owned a mere one-sixty-fourth share in an estate. Yet all of them

were subject to the same rules, forged to provide the British rulers with an assured tax income from millions of peasants without the inconvenience of having to bother with its risky collection.

The expectation behind the permanent settlement was that, over time, zamindars would become improving landlords who would invest in agricultural development. Fixed government taxes, rising produce prices and new land under the plough would leave more and more wealth in the zamindars' hands. By reinvesting in agriculture, they would boost the delta's economy. This did not happen, however, partly because zamindars lacked government support for agricultural development, improvement of infrastructure, technological innovation and marketing, and partly because there were easier ways to grow rich.

Popular strategies included squeezing the peasantry by (illegally) increasing rents and forcing tenants to pay contributions to events in the zamindar's family such as marriages, festivals, pilgrimages and funerals. The zamindars could enforce these illegal payments despite the fact that the permanent settlement had stripped them of their pre-British policing powers. In an attempt to discipline rural society, the British had set up a salaried police force answerable to state officials, but the zamindars were able to retain power over village policemen and they also hired bands of armed retainers to control their tenants. The state judicial system rarely reached down below the district level; and when it did, it had to find ways to accommodate landlords and village elders and their local ways of dispensing justice. These local ways outlived the British colonial period and the demise of the zamindars: in Bangladesh informal village dispute management by means of public gatherings (mojlish; *majliś*) easily survived into the twenty-first century.

As their incomes grew, zamindars began to distance themselves from agriculture and tax-collecting. They turned themselves into rentiers and shifted their responsibilities to intermediaries. Bengal's peasants produced so much wealth that these intermediaries were often able to follow the zamindars' example by appointing their own intermediaries. In this way, a multitiered system of leisured tenure-holders developed, all living off the wealth of the land. This system, known as sub-infeudation or pottonidari (*pattanidārī*), was most developed in what is now southern Bangladesh. For example, in the district of Borishal (Barisal) you had to cut through five to seven layers of intermediate tenures to get to the tiller of the soil.[9] In this way, the permanent settlement encouraged the development of a very hierarchical social structure dominated by an extensive leisured class.

CamScanner

There was another reason why the permanent settlement was a system with momentous consequences: it denied the peasantry any property rights in land. Previously there had been complex and locally variable bundles of property rights vested in both peasant producers and landlords. Now these rights were granted only to the landlords who could freely sell, mortgage or gift their land. In the eyes of the law, cultivators became mere tenants with a right to work the land – if they paid their rent regularly – but they could transfer this 'occupancy right' only by inheritance, not by sale. Not all tenants acquired occupancy rights, and over time a growing proportion of cultivators were no more than tenants-at-will whom the landlord could eject at any time. In this way colonial rural Bengal came to be dominated by zamindari landowners whose land was tilled by tenants with occupancy rights – in which case they were known as *rāiyat* – or without such rights.

The zamindari gentry benefited enormously from the colonial state's patronage. Many of them grew very rich indeed, acquired the lifestyle of aristocrats and built palatial mansions on their estates (Plate 6.1). Some also developed new cultural sensibilities (see box 'First-rate art in a country town').

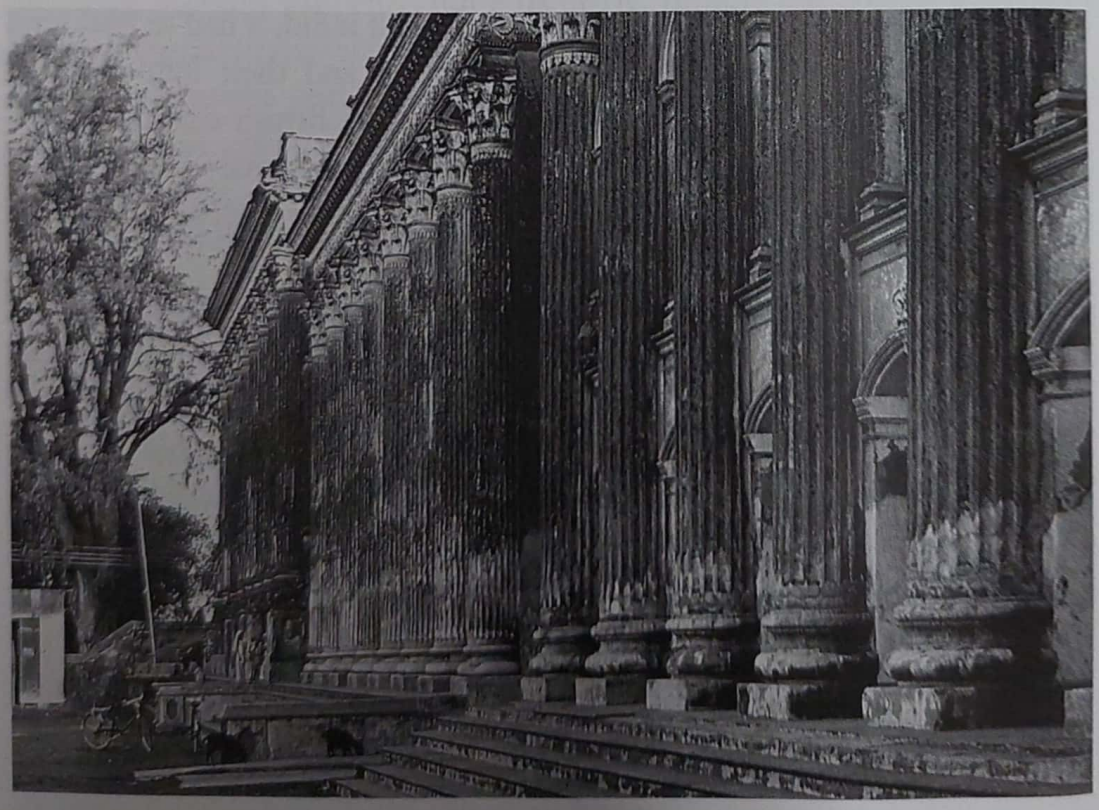


Plate 6.1 Remains of a zamindari mansion in central Bangladesh (*Baliati rājbāri* (palace), Manikganj district).[10]

First-rate art in a country town

In contemporary Bangladesh the zamindari landlords are remembered mainly as a bossy and parasitic gentry. Their grandiose lifestyle was based on the exploitation of peasant labour, and it is true that most of them gave little in return. There were exceptions, however: landlords who set up rural schools, libraries and clinics, improved the infrastructure of their estates, donated water supply systems or provided their tenants with support in times of scarcity.



Plate 6.2 Twenty-four enlightened ascetics are depicted on this stone sculpture from Dinajpur district. A votive object linked to the Jain religion, it dates from the ninth century. The Varendra Museum received it as a donation in 1933.

One priceless inheritance of zamindari initiative is the Varendra Research Museum in Rajshahi, a town in western Bangladesh. It is Bangladesh's oldest museum, established in 1910 by a group of aristocratic history buffs who wanted to promote the study of North Bengal. They gave their museum the ancient name for this region – the term also survives in 'Barind', the modern name for much of northern Bangladesh. The initiators of the Varendra Museum undertook numerous trips around the region to gather objects of antiquarian value, and they even sponsored and organised archaeological digs. Soon the museum was filling up with an outstanding collection from different historical periods.

After its main benefactors died, or fled to India in 1947, the museum went through a long period of serious neglect. Luckily, its collections survived this dark interlude and have now regained much of their former glory. Today the museum is best known for its spectacular sculptures of Hindu, Jain and Buddhist deities from the ninth to the twelfth centuries, its stone inscriptions, coins and terracottas, and a large collection of ancient palm-leaf manuscripts (Plate 6.2).[11]

At the same time the composition of the zamindari elite changed. Whereas Muslims had dominated during the reclamation of the eastern delta in the Mughal period, the British period saw an advance of Hindu landlords. Although neither Muslim zamindars nor Hindu tenants were rare by any means, in many parts of the eastern delta religious and class identities began to merge, with Hindu zamindars at the apex of a local society consisting largely of Muslim cultivators. In the western delta Hindu zamindars dominated as well but here the majority of the cultivators were also Hindus. This regional difference had no political ramifications in the early period of British rule, but it would become a highly salient political question towards its end.

CROPS FOR FAR-FLUNG MARKETS

A second major change during the British era was the introduction of large-scale export-oriented cash cropping. Earlier, Bengal's agriculture had been considerably commercialised, producing cotton, rice, sugar cane, mulberry, betel nut, opium and many other crops for various markets. These crops had been processed in Bengal's industries (for example cotton and silk textile manufacture) and often exported. In other words, commercial crop production was nothing new and cultivators had long been involved in market transactions, both as producers and as consumers.[12] What set the

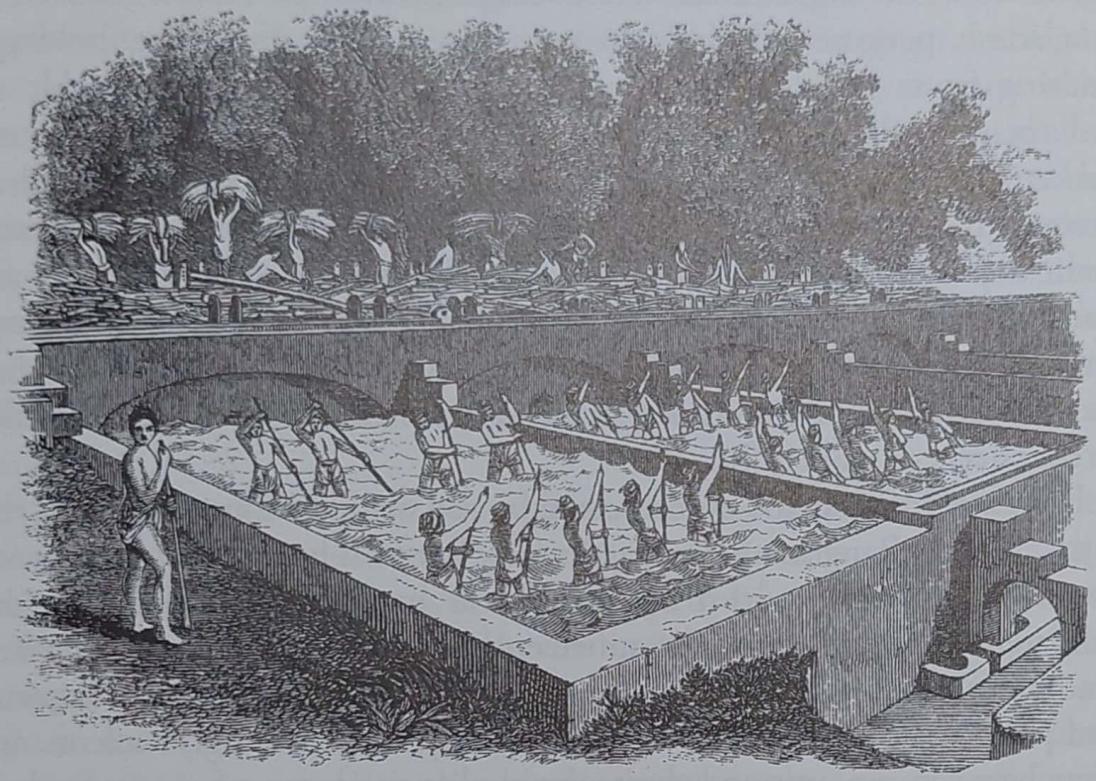


Plate 6.3 Producing indigo – a blue dyestuff derived from a field crop – for export to Europe.

British period apart, however, was the organisation of cash cropping, the scale of its production and a succession of new crops that began to be produced for overseas markets. European and South Asian capital was invested in the large-scale production of 'commodities of empire' – opium, indigo, tea, silk and jute – and the construction of railways to expedite exports. Some of these crops were grown under systems of coerced labour, others on plantations – capitalist agricultural enterprises run by Europeans – and yet others by indebted smallholders (Plate 6.3).

Cash cropping was important because it forged new ties between Bengal's rural economy and European and Asian markets. British imperial expansion, in South Asia as well as elsewhere in the continent, was buttressed by the wealth generated in Bengal, and at the same time cash cropping had a number of fundamental effects on the delta's society. It led to the beginnings of a developmentalist state (which would expand greatly after decolonisation)[13] and a new regional specialisation of the Bengal economy: sugar, indigo and silk were concentrated in western Bangladesh; eastern Bangladesh became the heartland of jute production; and tobacco was widespread in the north. Particular forms of social

organisation and land control were associated with these crops.[14] In eastern Bangladesh peasant smallholders were faced with dwindling holdings resulting from population growth and partible inheritance. Unable to feed their families with subsistence crops alone, they were forced into market production. The regional economy became highly monetised as foreign funds flowed in to finance agrarian exports – mainly jute – and credit-dependent peasant producers were fully exposed to international market uncertainties.[15] By contrast, in northern and western Bangladesh rural elites were major providers of agrarian credit, often in the form of rice loans to sharecroppers, and this shielded the primary producers from the direct effects of market forces.[16]

Both regional systems were affected by the world economic crisis of the 1930s. Eastern Bangladesh was particularly hard hit because the market for jute collapsed, credit dried up and it was impossible to return to the subsistence agriculture of the nineteenth century for lack of sufficient land. The result was widespread immiseration.[17] Old relations of social and political control broke down, giving way to increasingly violent conflicts between peasants and the regional elite made up of moneylenders, traders and landlords. In northern and western Bangladesh, the crisis initially intensified sharecroppers' and labourers' dependence on the grain-lending elite, but when land and crop prices recovered a decade later, sharecroppers began to demand better conditions, culminating in widespread agitations in the closing years of British rule.

NEW INSTITUTIONS OF RULE

Mughal rule had brought important administrative innovations to the Bengal delta. British rule introduced further major changes, some of which were to have long-lasting effects. The permanent settlement, discussed earlier in this chapter, was just one example of new ideas about law and rights that were translated into novel judicial institutions. Another was personal law, which was codified separately for followers of different religions. By treating certain classical religious writings as canonical legal texts, British intervention created four unified systems of personal law that deviated from, and dismissed, local customs and practices. Thus Muslims, Hindus, Buddhists and Christians in Bengal came to live under discrete systems of personal law that survive, with small adaptations, in Bangladesh today.[18]

A further example was the language of rule and education. By the 1830s the British dropped Persian – the Mughal language of rule – as the state's

official language. English-language schools and colleges trained a small proportion of the Bengali elite to prepare them for employment at the lower and middle levels of the colonial system. Two modern universities were set up in Kolkata (1857) and Dhaka (1921) and quickly established excellent academic reputations. Bengalis learned to see 'the West' and the wider world through British eyes and the filter of English-language texts, and this would be a lasting imprint. Long after decolonisation, Britain remained a cultural and moral yardstick and a resource for interpreting the world, until this position was gradually taken over by another former British colony, the United States, around the turn of the twenty-first century.

Education in the Bengali language also expanded under British rule. There was a long pre-colonial history of village education in public localities and private houses, usually funded by villagers themselves. Children learned to read and write in locally useful languages (Bengali for most; Persian, Arabic, Sanskrit, Pali, Chakma or Marma for some), as well as arithmetic, agricultural and commercial practice, and moral principles.[19] During the British period, Christian missionaries and, later, the government supported Bengali-language primary schools in towns and some villages, and a select group of children became literate. The vast majority of children did not go to school, however, because the curriculum was of little or no relevance to their working lives. They remained illiterate and received informal education from their families and local religious specialists.

This mixed English/Bengali educational system, introduced by the British, existed side by side with remnants of indigenous forms of religious education, and this arrangement still characterises contemporary education in Bangladesh: formal English-language schools coexist with Bengali-language ones, and religious education is imparted separately, primarily in Islamic schools known as moktobs (*maktab*; Plate 6.4) and madrashas (*mādrāsā*). It is only in recent years that some linguistic minorities in Bangladesh have been allowed to teach their primary-school-age children in their mother tongues.[20]

Education also took place outside formal education, for example regarding hygiene and health. Scientific medical ideas were not necessarily appropriate to the realities of medical practice in Bengal. As one European observer warned in 1855: 'The greatest danger which appears to beset the Native Medical Student is that of becoming too exclusively *English* in his lore and in his practice.'[21] Even so, Bengali-language texts began to spread new ideas about hygiene and health to many. British-era



Plate 6.4 Children studying at a moktob on Bangladesh's southernmost edge, St. Martin's Island, 2003.

demographic growth is thought to have owed much to the fact that people learned more about hygiene, and that medical practitioners had access to better medicines and new health institutions – clinics and hospitals.[22]

As communications improved across the Bengal delta – roads, bridges and railways made transport less dependent on waterways – the movement of goods and people accelerated. But there was a downside: the railways are thought to have had a disastrous effect on the delta's ecology. Their high embankments blocked waterways, created stagnant water bodies (which became breeding grounds for malaria), increased flooding and contributed to the agrarian stagnation of the late-colonial period.[23] In other words, they were an early example of what became a familiar occurrence in what is now Bangladesh: technocratic 'development' interventions that fail to factor in their ecological price tag.

Technological advances such as the telegraph, telephone and radio made it easier to spread information, and the span of state control increased as the police and army became better funded and organised. The state

remained firmly authoritarian, but political pressure compelled the British to experiment cautiously with restricted forms of popular representation in the closing decades of their rule.

These institutional innovations proved to be long-lived: despite turbulent state formation since British times, they remain clearly visible in Bangladesh's judicial, educational, health, engineering, military and political institutions today, as well as in the condescending treatment citizens often receive from bureaucrats. Even today, Bangladeshi citizens regularly have to use the tactics of colonial subjects – such as obsequious behaviour, handing over bribes, and offering petitions written in flowery and deferential style – to move state officials and politicians to lend them their ear.

SUFISM AND ITS OTHERS

British rule forced the inhabitants of the Bengal delta to reconsider many aspects of their worldviews. Their confrontation with a European culture, a racialised social order, a proselytising religion and Orientalist attitudes (which degraded local cultures as exotic and less advanced) had a great impact on their self-esteem. The new situation required a cultural response. It set in train a judicious recombination of social resources that would continue throughout the British era and helped shape the culture of contemporary Bangladesh.

To understand Bangladesh today it is especially important to look at how this response produced a new confrontation within Islam. In Chapter 3 we have seen that, in this region, Islam was not a religion of the sword or trade. It was not imposed from above but grew very gradually as an ideology of taming the forest and promoting settled agriculture. It became the religion of those who reclaimed the delta. Its cultural roots were twofold. Sufi mystics (pir; *pīr*) had been trickling into the region for centuries, and they had made Islamic ideas and practices accessible to the delta cultivators. Little by little these ideas and practices merged with locally existing religious ideas and worldviews, and finally came to dominate them. By the time the British conquered the delta, most inhabitants thought of themselves as Muslims. Theirs was a faith of rich diversity that converged on worship, devotion and spiritual union with Allah – core elements of Sufi understandings of the Quran and Hadith.[24]

Muslim religious life revolved around spiritual guides, shrines and mosques. Village mosques were used for daily prayer and contemplation

but the thousands of tomb-shrines that dotted the delta served another purpose. Known as mazar (*mājār*) or dorga (*dargā*), these saintly buildings embodied the spiritual and miraculous power of departed Sufi mystics who continued to act as conduits between the devotee, the Prophet and Allah. Shrines and other commemorative objects such as amulets and food – and even animals such as pigeons, fishes, crocodiles, turtles and monkeys – were considered to be full of the saint's charisma and blessing, and therefore they attracted pilgrims and supplicants eager to partake of the sanctified power (see box 'Reptilian blessings').[25] The ritual high point was the annual commemoration of the saint's death, known as urs (*urs*, *orch*), when thousands gathered to recall the saint's miracles in songs, dance and prayers.

Reptilian blessings

Coming upon a huge man-made pond in southwestern Bangladesh, you may wonder why a throng of people are gathered at its edge, staring intently at its tranquil water. A man calls out two names – Kalapahar and Dholapahar – and something stirs. As people start muttering, an old bearded man in skullcap flings a chicken into the pond. It turns out that these people are communing with a portly crocodile.

It was shortly after 1400 CE that an enterprising pioneer appeared in the Sundarban forest. His name was Khan Jahan Ali, an ethnic Uzbek or Turk. He was a classic charismatic colonist, keen to turn the forest into cultivable fields and able to achieve this by mobilising labour based on his reputation for religious power and piety. He reclaimed a large tract of land over which he ruled, and his followers constructed settlements, mosques and roads, and they dug truly enormous ponds. The one we are looking at covers a surface of some 60 hectares (or 150 acres). In it Khan Jahan Ali is thought to have kept crocodiles that he named Kalapahar and Dholapahar.

Khan Jahan Ali became famous as a Sufi mystic, and when he died in 1459 he was buried in the shrine that he had built on the bank of the pond. This burial place marking the frontier between land and water became a very prominent centre of Islamic devotion, and today, almost 600 years later, it is still a magnet for believers. Every day hundreds come to visit and pray, to circumambulate and touch the tomb, to donate money and buy souvenirs, and, most importantly, to receive the saint's blessing. His spiritual power is everywhere, mediated through the building and various objects, as well as through the sacred crocodiles in the pond. Devotees know that feeding them a chicken or a goat will bring good fortune and the fulfilment of their desires.

CamScanner



Plate 6.5 A sacred crocodile waiting for a ritual offering at Khan Jahan Ali's tomb, Bagerhat district, 2006.

During British rule this faith began to come under attack from groups who considered themselves to be more orthodox and who strove to 'purify' Islamic practices. They claimed to have a better, more doctrinaire interpretation of Islamic texts than Sufis had, and they were hostile to mystics and their role as spiritual guides. Most importantly, they rejected the notion that Islam could have multiple, equivalent, local forms and sought to impose a single, universal ritual format. They wanted to 'restore' the faith to what they thought of as its pristine piety, and they fought against what they considered its degeneration and un-Islamic elements.

The first wave of this rectifying campaign came in the 1820s and 1830s and was led by preachers who had spent long years in Mecca. They returned home with ideas derived from Arabian Wahhabism and the teachings of Shah Wali Allah of Delhi. These had produced puritanical movements whose more militant strands were keen to establish a muscular and politically resilient Islam. Among the best-known proponents in Bengal were Haji Shariatullah, who initiated the Faraizi movement, and Titu Mir, who headed the Tariqah-i-Muhammadiyah movement.[26] Both these religious purification movements would end up violently confronting the zamindars and the colonial state. The tension they articulated between

two streams of Islam in colonial Bengal – Sufi-inspired, locally embedded spirituality and reformist puritanism[27] – would wax and wane over the generations and flare up with each new attempt at 'purifying' Bengali Islam. The most recent wave took off around the turn of the twenty-first century and is currently ongoing in Bangladesh.

THE EMERGENCE OF OPPOSITIONAL RELIGIOUS CATEGORIES

As we have seen, the long-term interplay of different frontiers has given contemporary Bangladesh culture a particularly multilayered structure. These layers have always been in motion. It is no exaggeration to say that some of the identity shifts that occurred during British rule were fateful because they are still highly relevant in Bangladesh today. Foremost among these was the creation of two new political categories – 'Hindu' and 'Muslim' – which emerged at the turn of the twentieth century. These must be understood as new categories: they had only a superficial resemblance to previous meanings of these terms. Various forms of Islam and Hinduism had, of course, been important markers of worldview and social position in Bengal for centuries, but there was no overarching sense of a single 'Muslim community' or 'Hindu community'. The people adhering to each of these worldviews distinguished themselves from co-religionists in many ways – by class, sect, jurisprudence, gender and residence – and these identities were often more meaningful to them. In addition, the religious landscape of the Bengal delta was far more intricate. There were many who identified neither with 'Hinduism' nor with 'Islam' but with other faiths. Some of these are well known – for example, Buddhism and Christianity – but others less so. Among the local religions that came into existence during the British period are, for example, Matua and Trinath.[28]

It was under British rule that, for the first time, specific versions of Hindu and Muslim identity became politically acute. This resulted from a combination of factors that were not restricted to Bengal but concerned all of British India. First, British attempts to 'read' the colonised leaned heavily on categorisation by creed. They canonised religious identities in legal practice (for example personal law) and in the population censuses, which sought to order society by grouping people according to faith, sect and caste, as well as by 'race', 'tribe' and language. Second, British occupation fired various reformist movements. Some of these stressed the need for Muslims to unite against the foreign rulers and to emancipate themselves

vis-à-vis Hindus. Others were concerned with the proper education of women of different faith communities or the emancipation of groups of low-caste Bengalis.[29] Third, such ideas gathered strength as communications across the delta became easier with improved infrastructure and the dissemination of thought in print.

Things came to a head in 1905, when the British decided to divide Bengal into an eastern and a western half (see Chapter 8). At this point community identities irrevocably crystallised around the religious, pitching 'Muslim' against 'Hindu', and oppositional 'communal' politics was born. Ever since, politics and religious identity have been inextricably intertwined in Bengal.

THE RISE OF KOLKATA

A final major change during the British period was the emergence of Calcutta (now Kolkata) as the new centre of political power and cultural renewal. The city, established by the British in 1690, became the capital of colonial Bengal and, as British power expanded, also the capital of all of colonial India. This is where the government of India resided from 1757 to 1931. Up to the mid-nineteenth century this government was headed by successive governors-general who were appointed by the directors of the British East India Company. From 1858 the British monarch appointed the head of the government of India, now styled the Viceroy of India. Kolkata was the nerve centre of the colonial administration, and it developed rapidly. Ambitious Bengalis of all kinds soon flocked to the city. Among them were the scions of wealthy families with landed estates, often in the eastern delta, who set the cultural tone. Many soon acquired an English education and took up professions or positions in the colonial state. Historians later labelled this group, in which upper-caste Hindus predominated, the 'bhodrolok' (*bhadralok*; gentlefolk).[30] These people distinguished themselves from the vast majority of Bengalis, whom they referred to as 'chhotolok' (*chhoṭalok*), a pejorative term that can be translated as 'lowly people' or 'the little man'. The bhodrolok became pre-eminent cultural brokers between ordinary Bengalis and the British overlords, not just in Kolkata but also in the provincial towns and zamindari mansions of the East Bengal countryside.[31] Throughout Bengal, many sought to emulate the distinct and refined Kolkata-orientated bhodrolok lifestyle, but in eastern Bengal, where it was closely associated with (absentee) landlordism, elitism and casteism, this lifestyle was also deeply resented. Here, in market towns and small cities, a distinct mofussil (*maphasval*; countryside)

CamScanner

intelligentsia was taking shape. In post-colonial eastern Bengal the ideas, lifestyle and politics of the 'little man' would turn into crucial cultural resources.

Colonial Kolkata was more than Bengal's prime administrative and cultural city. It also emerged as its commercial and economic hub. Valuable cash crops such as opium (for the Chinese market) and indigo and tea (for the European market) were trans-shipped in its port, and sailors from eastern Bengal boarded seagoing vessels here. Jute from the fields of eastern Bengal was processed in Kolkata's many jute factories before being exported worldwide. From the 1850s a network of railway lines began to radiate from Kolkata to speed up the transport of goods from the hinterland. In the early-colonial period, many industrial centres in eastern Bengal had stagnated or decayed. The most dramatic example was Dhaka, which, until the early eighteenth century, had been the capital of Bengal and, until the British takeover, a major textile-exporting city. By 1800, however, British commercial policies and the rise of Kolkata had led to a sharp decline.[32] Dhaka's exports of fine textiles had halved and would soon disappear; its population had shrunk to about 200,000 and would dwindle to about 50,000 in the 1840s, Dhaka's lowest point (Plate 6.6).[33]



Plate 6.6 A view of Dhaka in 1823 ('The Great Kuttra', by Charles D'Oyly).

After that Dhaka began to recover gradually, mainly as a result of the jute trade and administrative expansion, but it did not recover the population level of 1800 until the 1930s and did not regain its industrial prowess until the 1970s.

After victory on the battlefield of Polashi in 1757, the British East India Company had proceeded to turn Bengal into the hub of its expanding colony of British India. A century later all of South Asia was ruled from Kolkata (now the second city of the British empire). The East India Company was no longer in charge: the British Crown had nationalised the colony and taken over direct control of India after the Indian Rebellion of 1857, in which Bengal had not been a hotspot. The Indian Ocean was now a 'British sea' because it was surrounded by territories under British jurisdiction. The Bengal delta became tightly integrated into the world economy, but under political and economic conditions that its residents could not control. A few of them benefited enormously from colonial patronage, but for many without close links to the colonial overlords it was a period of hardship.

CamScanner